

The Small Business AI Playbook

Marketing, reviews & ops in your spare time — by Obed Cudjoe

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No team, no budget, no time - and still a marketing presence that looks professional.

The 2-Hour AI Setup for Busy Owners

You don't have a marketing team. You have a shop, a phone, and whatever hours are left after the day actually runs. This book is for you: a system that turns AI into your part-time marketing department, review manager and admin clerk - for two hours of setup and thirty minutes a week.

The setup has four parts, and you can finish all of them in one evening. Part one: choose your tool. ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini - any of them works. What matters is that you use the same tool every time, so you can build history and favourites. Part two: write your business brief - a paragraph about what you sell, who buys it, your tone, and your location. You'll paste this at the top of every working session; it's the context that stops AI output from being generic.

Part three: collect your proof. Five real customer results - a compliment, a repeat order, a number (bookings, sales, reviews). You'll paste these into review replies, ads and posts. Proof is what separates marketing that works from marketing that looks like marketing. Part four: save the core prompts - the ones in chapter five of this book - into a document or favourites. Ten minutes to save, hours saved forever.

Two hours, four parts, done. The rest of this book shows you what to do with the system - and what to do when the system is working.

Action steps: (1) Book two hours this week. (2) Write your business brief in ten minutes. (3) Collect five proof points from your phone's photos, messages and reviews. Save everything into one file.

Marketing That Runs Itself (Social, Ads, Reviews)

The secret of small-business marketing is not brilliance; it's consistency. A shop that posts three times a week for a year beats a shop that posts brilliantly once. AI removes the effort that kills consistency - the 'what do I post' question - so consistency becomes possible.

Social: once a week, give the AI your week - what happened, what sold, what you noticed - and ask for three posts. The prompts in chapter five turn your real week into captions with your voice. The rule: every post starts from something real that happened. AI-generated ideas from thin air are how accounts start sounding like everyone else's.

Ads: before spending a cedi, use the ad prompts to draft three angles and test them small - GH¢ 20 a day tells you more than a month of guessing. The AI writes the copy; your phone's photos are the creative. Local targeting (5-15 km around you) turns a tiny budget into real foot traffic.

Reviews: the highest-ROI marketing in small business is asking happy customers for reviews and answering every single one. The review prompts draft the asks and the replies in minutes. Reply to positive reviews in 48 hours and negative ones in 24 - speed is a signal, and future customers read how you handle problems before they ever walk in.

That's the whole marketing department: three posts a week, one small ad test, a review system. Thirty minutes a week keeps it running. The machine does the typing; you supply the reality.

Action steps: (1) This week, run the three-posts prompt with your real week. (2) Reply to every review you've missed, using the reply prompts. (3) Start your review-request habit: one message per happy customer, sent within two hours.

Customer Service Without Hiring

Customers forgive slow service; they don't forgive ignored messages. But you physically cannot answer every WhatsApp, comment and review while also running the business. The answer is not hiring - it's templates with a human on top.

Start by writing down the twenty messages you receive most: price enquiries, hours, availability, complaints, compliments, the same three questions every week. For each one, use the prompts in chapter five to draft a reply in your voice. Save them as favourites. Now the first response to 80% of messages is a one-tap send - with your name on it.

Complaints deserve more care. The rule: never reply angry, never reply publicly before replying privately, and always move the fix offline ('message me and we'll sort it today'). The complaint-reply prompt drafts a calm, professional response in seconds - you add the specifics, and the specifics are what make it human.

When the AI replies, it's a template. When you add one personal line - the customer's name, the product they bought, what you'll actually do - it becomes service. That one line is the difference between 'they use chatbots' and 'they actually care'. Templates give you the speed; your line gives you the reputation.

Action steps: (1) List your twenty most-received messages. (2) Draft replies for the top five tonight. (3) Attach the 'one personal line' rule to each.

Ops & Admin: SOPs, Invoices, Scheduling

Behind every smooth-running small business is a pile of boring documents: standard operating procedures, invoices, schedules, policies. They don't need to be beautiful. They need to exist - and AI makes 'exist' achievable in minutes.

SOPs: the moment you find yourself explaining how to do something for the third time, write it down. 'Explain how to close the shop, in steps, so a new hire could follow it' - the AI produces the first draft; you fix the details. Ten SOPs cover most businesses: opening, closing, handling cash, dealing with complaints, restocking, cleaning, the weekly checklist. Your staff will thank you; your future self will thank you.

Invoices and policies: the AI drafts your invoice template language, refund policy, late-payment note and terms - in plain language, not legalese. Localize everything: prices in cedis, references to MoMo payment, your actual hours. Templates that exist get used; policies that live only in your head get improvised.

Scheduling and planning: use the AI for the weekly plan ('here's what happened this week, make next week's to-do list') and the monthly review ('here are my numbers, what should I focus on?'). These two prompts alone replace a business coach for most owners - because the discipline is the coaching, and the AI supplies the discipline.

Action steps: (1) Write your three most important SOPs this week. (2) Draft your refund and late-payment lines. (3) Run the weekly-plan prompt every Sunday - set a phone reminder.

The SMB Prompt Library: 15 Core Prompts

This chapter is your toolkit: fifteen prompts, each explained so you know when to use it and how to make it yours. They're in the companion pack (PKG-SMB-01) in Word and PDF.

Marketing: (1) Three posts from my week - feed it what actually happened; (2) Google review reply, positive - thank by name, mention a detail, invite back; (3) Google review reply, negative - apologize, stay calm, move offline; (4) Review request - send within two hours of the happy moment; (5) Local ad, three angles - small budget, tight radius; (6) Win-back message - a memory, what's new, an incentive; (7) Seasonal promo ideas - pick one, execute well.

Service: (8) Price enquiry reply - answer, then one value line; (9) Complaint reply - calm template plus your personal line; (10) Common question answers - the twenty-message list, drafted once; (11) Thank-you message for regulars - make loyalty visible.

Ops: (12) SOP writer - 'explain [task] so a new hire could do it'; (13) Refund policy draft - plain language, local rules; (14) Weekly plan - Sunday, ten minutes, real week in, next week out; (15) Monthly numbers review - revenue, what sold, what to focus on.

The rules of the library: fill every bracket with something real; run marketing prompts with real material; never send a template without your personal line; and once a month, delete prompts you never use - a short library you use beats a long one you don't.

Action steps: (1) Bookmark or save these fifteen. (2) This week, run prompts 1, 2 and 14. (3) Next week, add one more. The system compounds.

Your Weekly 30-Minute AI Routine

Systems fail when they demand more time than you have. This one demands thirty minutes a week, on a schedule you choose - Sunday evening works for most owners. Set the reminder now.

Minutes 0-5: the weekly plan. Paste last week's reality into prompt 14: what happened, what sold, what broke, what's coming. Get the week's to-do list back, prioritized. Minutes 5-15: marketing. Run prompt 1 with your real week: three posts. Draft the review replies (prompt 2 or 3) for anything new. One ad variant if you're testing. Minutes 15-25: service. Clear the message backlog with the templates - but add your personal line to every reply. Minutes 25-30: ops and review. Update any SOP that proved wrong this week. Check the month's numbers if it's month-end. Done.

That's the routine. Three posts, all reviews answered, every message handled, the week planned - thirty minutes. The compounding happens quietly: a month of consistent posts, a stack of answered reviews, a library of SOPs, and a business that looks - from the outside - like it has a marketing department.

When things go wrong - a bad review goes viral, a complaint spirals - the routine still holds: the same prompts, the same calm templates, plus your personal line. Small businesses survive chaos on systems, not heroics.

Final advice from someone who runs this exact system: the first week feels like effort, the fourth week feels like routine, and the twelfth week is when a customer mentions 'your social media is really active lately'. That's the moment you'll know it's working.

Action steps: (1) Set the Sunday-evening reminder right now. (2) Run the first 30-minute session this week. (3) In twelve weeks, count how many customers mentioned your marketing.